

Colonialism

During the 1800s, Europeans colonized areas in Africa, introducing Christianity, and taking economic control. They used African workers to grow or mine precious raw materials, but sent the materials to be manufactured in Europe and America – where profits stayed. During this period, slavery was at its height as Europeans kidnapped Africans to work in the Americas.

African Diaspora

The slave trade scattered more than 20 million Africans throughout the Americas and Europe, undermining African culture in the process. Over the centuries, the dispersed descendants of these slaves became known as the African Diaspora.



Traditional
witch
doctors

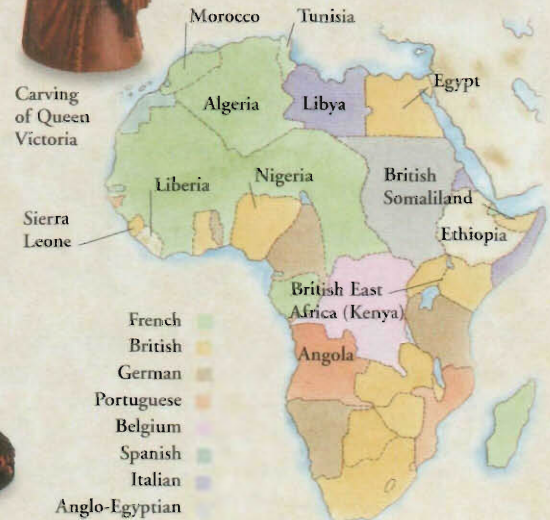
Voodoo voice
disguiser

Voodoo
In 19th-century Caribbean colonies, traditional ancestor worship combined with Christianity to produce a religion called voodoo.



Scramble for Africa

In 1884, European leaders decided that their countries could claim African territories as colonies when occupied by Europeans. This started a scramble to the interior in search of new lands. By 1902, all of Africa was colonized, except Liberia and Ethiopia.



Carving of Queen Victoria

Sierra Leone

French
British
German
Portuguese
Belgium
Spanish
Italian
Anglo-Egyptian



African carving of a European

Christianity

Europe sent missionaries to Africa to set up schools and churches, and to convert Africans to Christianity. They also tried to abolish African traditional religions, often punishing those who still practised them.

World Wars I and II

Although both world wars were European, thousands of Africans lost their lives as colonial rulers forced them to join the army. One cause of World War I was German resentment against other European countries during colonization. In World War II, North Africa became a battleground, as German and Italian forces invaded British- and French-ruled territories.

World War I

When World War I broke out in 1914, the Ottoman Empire controlled North Africa. The Egyptians colluded with the British to overthrow Turkish rule, and they were helped from 1916 to 1918 by the eccentric soldier and author Thomas Edward Lawrence (1888–1935), who became famous as Lawrence of Arabia. After the war, Egypt became a British protectorate but signed a treaty for independence in 1922.



Herero and Nama tribes fight German colonialists, Namibia, 1904

African resistance

Africans strenuously resisted colonialism. The Ethiopians fought to stay independent and won (1896); Zimbabwe and Sudan rebelled against the British (1896 and 1920); tribes in Angola tried to overthrow the Portuguese (1902); in Namibia and Tanzania, thousands were killed in uprisings against the Germans (1904–1908); and in Nigeria, tribes revolted against French rule (1920s).



TE Lawrence



African Front

Operation Torch

In 1942, American and British soldiers landed in Morocco and Algeria in an invasion called Operation Torch. Joined by the French, the Allies attacked the German and Italian armies, forcing them into Tunisia. After a bloody battle, Germany's Afrika Korps surrendered. The war on African soil was over by May 1943.



Troops at
El Alamein, Egypt

El Alamein

In 1941, Italian and German forces invaded North African territories held by the British. The British recruited soldiers from their colonies of Nigeria, Ghana, and Sierra Leone to join the fight on their behalf. In 1942, the British defeated the Germans at the historic battle of El Alamein. This battle was a turning point in the war.

Haile Selassie

Emperor Haile Selassie of Ethiopia (r.1930–74) led his troops against the Italian invasion of 1935. The Italians forced the emperor into exile in 1936, but he returned in 1941. Haile Selassie instituted reforms, suppressed slavery, and worked with the Organization of African Unity. In 1974, the army overthrew the emperor, installing military rule. He died in exile in 1975 aged 84.

